External Shading and Night Ventilation for Summer Cooling in a Hangzhou Residential Prototype

Abstract

This study quantifies the summer cooling benefits of external shading and night ventilation in a Hangzhou residential prototype. A two-zone thermal-network model compared four scenarios using 2025 and 2026 weather. Combining 50% window direct-solar reduction with temperature-controlled night ventilation lowered summer mean free-running air temperature by 2.12°C and 1.85°C, overheating degree-hours above 28°C by 17.5% and 17.7%, and ideal sensible cooling demand at 26°C by 7.01% and 6.44%. The combination ranked first across twenty tested input sets. Shading supplied most cooling-demand reduction, while night ventilation contributed additional heat removal when outdoor temperatures permitted. The results support coordinated solar control and night-time heat discharge for the modelled dwelling.

1. Introduction

Passive cooling can improve summer building performance by reducing heat entry and using cooler outdoor air to discharge stored heat. Short et al. (2018) examined solar exposure, enclosed balconies and ventilation in Hangzhou apartments, while Artmann et al. (2008) identified weather, airflow and thermal storage as important determinants of night cooling. Building on these mechanisms, this study evaluates how much external shading, night ventilation and their combination can reduce overheating and sensible cooling demand in a residential prototype. Comparing free-running and 26°C ideal-cooling operation reveals how operating conditions affect the value of each measure and provides a basis for coordinating them in summer design.

2. Methods

A public floor plan (HZXQF, n.d.) informed a reconstructed prototype comprising a 41.1 m² living zone and a separate 6.3 m² enclosed balcony. An assumed 2.7 m height gives volumes of 110.97 and 17.01 m³. Both zones are well mixed; the partition remains closed. Horizontal boundaries and two east-facing wall segments are adiabatic. Assumed external whole-window areas are 3.525 and 14.07 m². Each zone contains an air node and an effective thermal-mass node. Air balances include envelope conduction, ventilation, interzone exchange, gains and cooling; mass nodes exchange heat with the air and receive allocated gains.

Wall resistance uses layer thicknesses and conductivities from Short et al. (2018, supplementary Table S1). Effective heat capacity, assumed independently of uncertain material heat capacities, is 165 kJ/(m² K). Whole-window U = 6.7 W/(m² K) and SHGC = 0.70 represent clear single-glazed aluminium windows (NSW Government, n.d.). Closed/open total air-change rates of 0.44/1.51 per hour use summer-night bedroom medians from Hou et al. (2019, Table 6); transferring them to these zones is a modelling assumption. Living-zone gains are 16.7 W/m² from 18:00–08:00 and 30% otherwise. The magnitude draws on Short et al.; this schedule is independently assumed, not measured.

ERA5 data obtained through Open-Meteo provide 2,208 hourly records per summer, with no missing values. Radiation represents the preceding hour; solar position uses its midpoint and outdoor temperature uses adjacent endpoint means (Open-Meteo, n.d.). Preserving the source records yields intervals from 31 May 23:00 to 31 August 23:00, UTC+8; the first temperature is held constant for the missing initial endpoint. Direct, isotropic diffuse and ground-reflected radiation are calculated for each facade. An assumed 25% of admitted balcony solar gain is

allocated to the living zone, with the remainder retained in the balcony, avoiding double counting.

S0 has background ventilation only; S1 removes 50% of window direct radiation; S2 enables night ventilation; S3 combines both. Each zone independently switches to the open-window total rate during 21:00–07:00 when indoor air is at least 1 K warmer than outdoors. Free-running simulations evaluate DH28 = Σmax(Tin − 28, 0)Δt, in K h, using 28°C as a research threshold. Separate ideal-cooling simulations impose a continuously available 26°C upper limit in the living zone only and sum sensible heat removal in kWh_th. They include neither latent loads nor equipment electricity.

Backward Euler integration uses 300 s steps after 28 days of repeated-first-week warm-up. In the 2025 baseline checks, halving the step changed key cumulative metrics by less than 0.006%; energy-balance and initialization checks also passed. These checks support numerically stable scenario comparisons. Twenty input sets, including the baseline, test airflow, thermal mass, windows, shading and other assumptions; each variant is compared with its own S0.

3. Results

Table 1. Baseline scenario comparison; cooling is ideal sensible heat removal.

Year	Case	DH28 (K h)	Cooling (kWh_th)	Cooling cut (%)
2025	S0	26,593.1	3,757.0	0.00
2025	S1	24,601.3	3,514.7	6.45
2025	S2	23,724.5	3,735.3	0.58
2025	S3	21,935.9	3,493.8	7.01
2026	S0	22,884.1	3,308.6	0.00
2026	S1	21,348.8	3,121.6	5.65
2026	S2	20,206.4	3,281.7	0.82
2026	S3	18,830.9	3,095.4	6.44

DH28 refers to free running; cooling cuts are relative to the same year’s S0.

All three measures improved baseline performance (Table 1). S3 reduced mean free-running air temperature by 2.12°C in 2025 and 1.85°C in 2026, and DH28 by 17.5% and 17.7%. Night ventilation alone reduced DH28 more than the tested 50% direct shading; shading produced the greater reduction in ideal cooling demand. Residual S3 overheating lasted 2,172.0 and 2,179.8 of 2,208 hours, so the principal free-running benefit was lower overheating intensity.

S3 reduced ideal demand by 263.2 kWh_th in 2025, from 3,757.0 to 3,493.8 kWh_th, and by 213.2 kWh_th in 2026, from 3,308.6 to 3,095.4 kWh_th. Across all twenty input sets, S3 had the lowest DH28 and cooling demand; individual-measure rankings varied. For demand D, interaction I = (D0 − D3) − (D0 − D1) − (D0 − D2) was −203.1 and −159.7 K h for DH28, and −0.88 and −0.74 kWh_th for cooling. Combined cooling benefits were approximately additive with slight diminishing returns.

4. Discussion

The results support two complementary design actions: reduce daytime solar input and discharge heat during cooler night hours. Living-zone ventilation operated throughout the 920-hour night window in free-running S2 and S3. With ideal cooling, 164 hours in 2025 and 206 hours in 2026 met the opening rule: indoor air near 26°C generally needs outdoor air

near or below 25°C to provide the specified 1 K difference. Temperature-controlled opening therefore targets the available sensible cooling opportunity. Under the tested 26°C schedule, external shading is the principal demand-reduction measure, complemented by night ventilation when this opportunity occurs.

Heat balances clarify which paths solar control can address. In 2025, the living zone received 457.7 kWh_th through its own external windows and 507.9 kWh_th as allocated secondary balcony solar gain, while transferring a net 243.7 kWh_th to the balcony through the partition. Distinguishing these paths supports including balcony glazing in solar-control assessment while retaining its buffer-zone heat exchange. Together with the stable combination ranking, this provides a physical basis for evaluating solar exclusion and night-time discharge as a coordinated strategy.

The analysis is an uncalibrated prototype comparison. Baseline free-running peaks of 50.11°C and 47.84°C depend on assumed glazing, internal gains, balcony solar allocation and simplified thermal boundaries; overhang and reduced-gain comparisons changed absolute outcomes. Fixed airflow, lumped storage, omitted sky longwave exchange and two summers also bound interpretation. Actual operation additionally involves humidity, rain, security and noise. These factors define priorities for refining the estimated benefits and testing application to particular dwellings.

5. Conclusion

For the modelled Hangzhou dwelling, combining external shading and night ventilation achieved a 1.85–2.12°C reduction in summer mean free-running air temperature, a 17.5–17.7% reduction in overheating degree-hours above 28°C, and a 6.44–7.01% reduction in ideal sensible cooling demand at 26°C. Its first-place ranking across twenty tested input sets supports using the measures together under the studied conditions.

The resulting design priority is to reduce daytime solar gains through external shading and use night ventilation to provide additional heat removal whenever the outdoor temperature is at least 1 K below indoor temperature. This coordinated strategy can moderate summer overheating and reduce the sensible cooling duty of active systems.

References

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